



PERGAMON

International Journal of Intercultural Relations
26 (2002) 59–89

International Journal of
INTERCULTURAL
RELATIONS

www.elsevier.com/locate/ijintrel

Boundary work: American ethnographers as intercultural communicators in Japan

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Abstract

An intriguing window on Japanese/American intercultural relations can be found in American ethnographers' in-depth accounts of their difficulties with Japanese informants. Although the literature contains excellent self-analyses of this kind, this body of data has yet to be mined for general lessons regarding communication between Americans and Japanese. This paper addresses that gap by comparing several reflexive accounts of doing ethnography in Japan: Matthews Hamabata's *Crested Kimono*, Gail Bernstein's *Haruko's World*, Liza Dalby's *Geisha*, and *Crafting Selves* by Dorinne Kondo. Examining the barriers to Japanese/American communication through this special lens reveals a complicated picture. On the one hand, familiar factors, such as the universalism of Americans, their emphasis upon individual autonomy in social relations, and the Japanese matrix of constantly shifting in-group/out-group relations are often the dominant influences on intercultural interactions. Yet, on the other hand, situational contexts and the value orientations and political commitments of the actors clearly do modify the expression of such factors and sometimes even reverse the expected outcomes. The present approach facilitates the representation of these complex relationships. A qualitative analysis in which an objectively framed comparison aimed at generalization rests upon the non-reified foundation of several reflexive ethnographies, shows promise as one strategy for transcending the stalemate between traditional group-based interpretations of culture and more recent approaches stressing individual agency and internal cultural diversity. This paper also illustrates some advantages of an anthropological approach to communication between the members of two cultures whose differences have long been a focus of interculturalist research and examines implications for models of collectivist and individualist cultures. © 2002 Elsevier Science Ltd. All rights reserved.

Keywords: Intercultural; Communication; Japanese; Americans; Ethnography; Anthropology

One major untapped resource for analyzing the difficulties of Japanese/western intercultural interactions can be found in foreign ethnographers' discussions of the

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